been asked to freeze the delivery since his government felt that the material fell under the Missile Technology Control Regime. The supplier had dispatched the cargo, but he would be asking the Indian port authorities not to release it; he would compensate us as per the contract.

I flew to Madras. I told the port officer that the consignment is of great national importance, but he said he was helpless as he just got a message that it should be sent back without delivering it to ISRO.

'What if you haven't got that message?' I said.

'But I have got the message.'

'Have you acknowledged the receipt of the message?'

'Not yet.'

'Listen,' I pulled my chair forward. 'This consignment is of supreme importance to the nation.

We are making a rocket, and the Americans are not happy about it. Listen to what I say, and I will get you the endorsement from the highest office in this country if that comes to that. Just release the consignment and say you got the message late.'

It was not as difficult as I thought. He agreed. I soon left with the consignment to Trivandum, from where it would be taken to the fabrication centre.

It was against this background that I hastened to ship out the first tankage made by Air Liquide, though it meant additional expenditure since two tankages could have been transported home at the same cost. Dhawan understood my urgency, stood by me and, when the CAG pointed a finger at ISRO, he got the PMO to endorse what we had done.

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As the procurement and fabrication of the hardware went on, a team headed by R Natarajan was working on liquid propellants and storage systems. Natarajan, a chemical engineer who continues to research at VIT University, Vellore now, had spent four months in Vernon in 1977. This